Alexander Williams Tolbert

Assistant Professor of Data and Decision Sciences, Emory University
Secondary Appointments: Philosophy, Computer Science, African American Studies
Faculty Fellow, Emory Center for Ethics; Affiliate, Center for Mind, Brain, and Culture
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Education

- **PhD in Philosophy**, University of Pennsylvania, 2019–2023. Advisors: Michael Kearns, Quayshawn Spencer, Anita Allen. Committee: Samuel Freeman, Aaron Roth, Scott Weinstein
- **M.A. in Statistics**, Wharton School, University of Pennsylvania, 2019–2023
- **M.S. in Biochemistry**, Virginia Tech, 2017–2019
- **M.A. in Philosophy**, Virginia Tech, 2017–2019
- **B.S. in Biology**, University of Mobile, 2009–2013

Academic Appointments

- **Assistant Professor** (2024–present), Department of Data and Decision Sciences, Emory University
- **Postdoctoral Researcher** (2023–2024), Emory University
- **Visiting Graduate Scholar** (2020), CUNY Graduate Center (Supervisor: Charles Mills)

Areas of Specialization

Philosophy of Science, Machine Learning, Causal Inference, Philosophy, Politics, and Economics (PPE)

Publications

PEER-REVIEWED ARTICLES

Tolbert, A. W. (forthcoming). Why AI ethics is not about AI. *Philosophical Studies*.

Tolbert, A. W. (forthcoming). Race as a statistical regime. *Journal of Causal Inference*.

Bouyamourn, A., & Tolbert, A. W. (2026). Escaping the subprime trap in algorithmic lending [Forthcoming]. *Proceedings of the 7th Symposium on Foundations of Responsible Computing (FORC 2026)*. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2502.17816

Huang, J., Lu, J., & Tolbert, A. W. (2026). Causal feature learning in the social sciences [Forthcoming]. *Proceedings of the ACM Conference on Equity and Access in Algorithms, Mechanisms, and Optimization (EAAMO 2026)*. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2503.12784

Blum, A., Diana, E., Ravichandran, K., & Tolbert, A. W. (2026). A theoretical model for grit in pursuing ambitious ends [Forthcoming]. *Proceedings of the AAAI Conference on Artificial Intelligence*. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2503.02952

Tolbert, A. W. (2025). The racial algorithm: Reassessing scientific legitimacy in a value-laden world [Forthcoming]. *Critical Philosophy of Race*. https://philpapers.org/rec/TOLTRA-2

Tolbert, A. W., & Smith, B. (2025). The problem of generics in LLM training. *Proceedings of the 2025 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency*, 1275–1280. https://doi.org/10.1145/3715275.3732085

Behzad, T., Casacuberta, S., Diana, E. R., & Tolbert, A. W. (2025). Reconciling predictive multiplicity in practice. *Proceedings of the 2025 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency*, 3350–3369. https://doi.org/10.1145/3715275.3732216

Shukla, P., Chinchure, A., Diana, E., Tolbert, A. W., Hosanagar, K., Balasubramanian, V. N., Sigal, L., & Turk, M. A. (2025). Mitigate one, skew another? Tackling intersectional biases in text-to-image models [Forthcoming, accepted to Findings of ACL at EMNLP 2025]. *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics: EMNLP 2025*. https://doi.org/10.48550/arXiv.2505.17280

Tolbert, A. W. (2025). An epistemic argument for reparations: A solution to the problem of social stratification in causal modeling [Published online 18 April 2025]. *Synthese*, 205(179). https://doi.org/10.1007/s11229-024-04901-8

Tolbert, A. W. (2025). Restricted racial realism: Heterogeneous effects and the instability of race in social science. *Philosophy of the Social Sciences*, 55(2), 146–164. https://doi.org/10.1177/00483931241299884

Tolbert, A. W. (2025). Why causal inference is necessary for algorithmic fairness [Published online 10 September 2025]. *Synthese*, 206(162). https://doi.org/10.1007/s11229-025-05044-0

Roth, A., & Tolbert, A. W. (2025). Resolving the reference class problem at scale. *Philosophy of Science*, 1–15. https://doi.org/10.1017/psa.2025.17

Tolbert, A. W. (2024). Causal agnosticism about race: Variable selection problems in causal inference. *Philosophy of Science*, 91(5), 1098–1108. https://doi.org/10.1017/psa.2023.166

Diana, E., Tolbert, A. W., Ravichandran, K., & Blum, A. (2025). Pessimism traps and algorithmic interventions. *6th Symposium on Foundations of Responsible Computing (FORC 2025)*, 329, 5:1–5:19. https://doi.org/10.4230/LIPIcs.FORC.2025.5

Tolbert, A. W. (2026). Correcting underrepresentation and intersectional bias for classification. *American Philosophical Quarterly*. https://philpapers.org/rec/TOLCUA

Roth, A., Tolbert, A. W., & Weinstein, S. (2023). Reconciling individual probability forecasts. *Proceedings of the 2023 ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency*, 101–110. https://doi.org/10.1145/3593013.3593980

BOOK CHAPTERS

Tolbert, A. W. (2026). Algorithmic abolitionism and the racial algorithm [Invited contribution, Forthcoming]. In K. C. Elliott & T. Richards (Eds.), *The Routledge handbook of values and science*. Routledge. https://philpapers.org/rec/TOLAAA-6

REVISE AND RESUBMIT

Tolbert, A. W. (2025). A capabilities approach for causal fairness [Revise and resubmit]. *Observational Studies*.

Selected Talks and Presentations

CONFERENCES

- *Pacific APA, 2025* – Pessimism Traps and a Theoretical Model of Grit
- *SWEET Conference, Florida, 2025* – Theoretical Model of Grit
- *PPE Colloquium, Buffalo, 2024* – Causal Agnosticism About Race
- *PhilML’24, Tübingen, 2024* – Causal Agnosticism About Race
- *PSA Biennial Meeting, 2022* – Causal Race Agnosticism
- *PSA Biennial Meeting, 2021* – Against Predictive Invariance
- *APA Pacific Division, 2021* – Causation and Algorithmic Fairness
- *APA Eastern Division, 2021* – Causation and Algorithmic Fairness
- *BIAS Conference, 2021* – Against Predictive Invariance

COLLOQUIA AND INVITED TALKS

- *AI Symposium, Morgan State, 2025* – Pessimism Traps and a Theoretical Model of Grit
- *Tepper OR Colloquium, CMU, 2024* – Causal Agnosticism About Race
- *First Paris Conference on Frontiers of Economics and Philosophy, 2024* – Algorithms, Justice, and the Urban Ghetto
- *TTIC Colloquium, 2024* – Causal Agnosticism About Race
- *Philosophy of AI (PhAI), 2023* – Algorithms, Justice, and the Urban Ghetto
- *TOC4Fairness Seminar, Simons Foundation, 2022* – Reference Class Problems, Model Multiplicity
- *Penn Law Symposium on Innovation and Criminal Justice, 2022* – Algorithms in Criminal Justice (Panel)
- *Ernest E. Just Biomedical Society, Penn, 2020* – Causation and Algorithmic Fairness

- *Philosophy and Physical Computing, 2019* – Dynamics and Biochemical Kinds
- *Virginia Tech Biochemistry Speakers Series, 2019* – Inositol Kinase Function
- *Philosophy and Physical Computing, 2018* – Finding Natural Kinds

Professional Service

- Guest Editor, *American Philosophical Quarterly*, Special Issue on AI (2025)
- Co-Organizer, AI, Systems & Society Conference, Emory University (2025)
- Founder, Black Philosophy of AI Roundtable, Emory University (2024)

University and Graduate Service

- Organizer, AI Systems and Society Reading Group, Emory QTM (2023–2024)
- Founder, W. E. B. Du Bois & Ida B. Wells Symposium on Socially Aware Data Science (2022–)
- Founder, Penn Philosophy of Computation and Data Workshop (2021–)
- Organizer, Penn-Rutgers Philosophy of Race Reading Group (2020–)
- Africana Summer Institute Fellow, University of Pennsylvania (2020–2021)
- Co-President, Minorities and Philosophy (MAP), Virginia Tech (2018–2019)
- Editorial Assistant, *HOPOS* (2018–2019)

Professional Experience

- **Amazon Web Services (Remote)** – Research Scientist Intern, Summer 2021. Project: Algorithmic Framework for Bias. Supervisor: Peter Hallinan | Language: Python
- **Amazon Web Services (Remote)** – Research Scientist II Intern, Summer–Fall 2022. Project: Algorithmic Harm and Bias Database. Supervisor: Peter Hallinan | Language: Python
- **Wharton Sports Analytics and Business Initiative, UPenn** – Instructor, Summer 2022. Moneyball Academy: teaching data science and coding (R) to underrepresented students

Awards and Grants

- Fontaine Fellow, University of Pennsylvania (2019–2023)
- Graduate Scholar, MAOP Fellowship, Virginia Tech (2017–2019)

Technical Skills

Proficient: R, Python **Familiar:** SQL, Java **Tools:** LaTeX, Git

References

Available upon request.